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DEALER BEST PRACTICE SERIES

CRC Hand Tool Management

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1.0 Introduction

Easy access to the correct tools is vital to shop efficiency. The majority of hand tools in most shops are owned by the technician and stored in his own personal toolbox. Mechanics owning their tools and toolboxes has been a common practice for many years.

As more dealers focus on high efficiency, workflow, and optimum use of facility space, the culture of oversized personal toolboxes in the shop may no longer be acceptable. As shops have gone to second and even third shifts, some dealers have noticed that 20% or more of the available floor space in a work bay is occupied by personal toolboxes.

A Component Rebuild Center has several types of tools:

- Generic hand tools: frequently used by a single technician, typically stored in a technician's toolbox, and located in their work area when in use.
- Area specific, community tools: frequently used tools by a group of technicians in a specific area of the shop (i.e. engine assembly bays). They are typically stored in an on-floor "community" storage cabinet.
- Supplies, hardware, chemicals, etc., are stored in several areas of the shop, with both personal and community storage methods.
- Tool crib stored tools. They are less frequently used tools.

The key to effective tool (and tool cost) management is to place required tools in the work areas where they are used, and to minimize the requirements for a mechanic to own and store his own tools. Oversized toolboxes congest the shop floor, are difficult to move, and increase tool costs. Second and third shift requirements multiply the number of toolboxes present per work bay. Good tool management programs result in standard, smaller toolboxes and lower tool costs.

2.0 Best Practice Description

Toolbox sizes tend to grow over time, often unnoticed because it occurs gradually. Many technicians own the toolboxes they use and eventually upgrade to larger and larger capacity toolboxes because:

- Seldom used but critical community tools are not readily available or consistently maintained. Technicians end up buying too many of these tools for convenience.
- The technician owns the toolbox and shop management does not regulate its size.
- Generic supplies are not provided in a convenient, on-floor location for technician use. Technicians often collect and store a "parts stash" in their toolbox.
- Technicians take pride in their tool collection, and take pride in displaying bigger, more extravagant toolboxes.

Effective tool management provides the right tools at the right place. Effective tool management includes many of these attributes:

- All personal toolboxes are a standard size.
- Shops provide the toolboxes, buying them in bulk to reduce costs. Some shops only provide the lower roller cabinet (20" deep, 30" wide, and 38" tall), and the technician can add the upper tool chest as needed.

- Shops provide wall-mounted foldout toolboxes that store required work bay tools with peg-board arrangements.
- Community tool cabinets are located on-floor for technicians to quickly retrieve locally needed special tools.
- Community hardware and chemical supply cabinets are located on the shop floor for easy retrieval. Quick inventory order sheets are often provided at the cabinet for easy re-supply charge-outs by technicians as needed. The parts department inventories the cabinets.
- Portable workbenches are located in each work bay for mid-bay workstations. This helps eliminate the large toolbox/workbench combinations.

Examples of common area tool and supply storage.

3.0 Implementation Steps

1) Determine the anticipated type/quantity of tools needed in the shop for each technician and/or work bay. Include:
   a) Standard hand-tools for each technician.
   b) Community tools for specific regions of the shop (example; engine disassembly bays).
   c) Chemicals needed to process the product (examples; gasket adhesive, anti-seize, etc).
2) Establish the types and number of toolboxes needed to store the tools.
   a) Personal, or personally assigned, roll-around toolboxes
   b) Wall-mounted foldout toolboxes for a specific work bay.
   c) Community tool cabinets for high cost, special, or seldom used tools.
   d) Community tool racks for items not applicable to a cabinet enclosure, such as straps, chains, pry bars, cribbing, etc.
   e) Community reference centers - identically organized for universal retrieval methods.
   f) Arrange for off-shift toolbox parking areas. Areas in the path between the workshop and the washroom work well.
3) Determine the anticipated type/quantity of hardware/chemicals/consumables needed.
4) Establish the types and quantity of community cabinets needed to store the needed hardware/chemicals/consumables/references:
   a) Include charge-out sheets as needed.
   b) Anticipate the frequency of use when locating the centers.

5) Identify other workbench/other storage drawers that may become personal stashes for tools, literature, parts, etc. Determine which will be eliminated.
6) Develop a toolbox/storage transition plan. Include:
   a) Temporary storage accommodations as needed for eliminated toolboxes.
   b) Time frames for strategic changes for each shop/area.
   c) Changes of responsibility for community tools/supply inventories.
7) Present strategy to shop employees. For many mechanics, realize that this is a culture change and has some emotional factors. Some mechanics have made a large personal investment in their tools and toolbox.
8) Install the equipment/layout changes into the shop (may occur in phases as needed).
9) Train employees to use the new procedures/equipment.
10) Review process performance once established.
11) Establish and install any adjustments as needed.

4.0 Benefits

- Increased service capacity – Less space is consumed by smaller toolboxes. Fewer tools are duplicated with community tool centers. Off-shift toolboxes may be stored outside of the production area.
- Reduced labor:
  - The work bays are less congested with smaller/fewer toolboxes.
    - There are clearer paths around the product and subassembly work..
    - There is more room to store, and have access to staged parts.
    - There is less to move, and fewer hard-to-reach corners when cleaning bays.
  - Technicians quickly move from bay to bay with smaller toolboxes and less congestion.
  - Supplies are more quickly available through organized supply centers.
- Job flexibility – Bay to bay moves are easier with smaller toolboxes
- Reduced cost – Fewer tools are needed with organized community tool centers. Fewer seldom-used tools are purchased when they are inventoried in the centers.

5.0 Resources Required

- Investment costs vary depending on what program is chosen:
  - Roller cabinets provided with top chests ($750- $1,000 US each).
  - Roller cabinets only provided ($500- $700 US each).
  - Wall-mounted fold-out tool boxes (cost varies with size/quality)
- Support Equipment/Efforts
  - Shared tool cabinets and inventories for on-floor tool centers.
  - Supply cabinets and inventory for on-floor community centers.
  - Labor in transferring tools/cabinets in and out of shop.
- People
  - Establish current tool/equipment/cost concerns with team.
  - Establish process, layout, and equipment improvements through team.
- Training
  - Establish the improvement benefits with the production team.
  - Define, establish, and enforce the new process and duties with the production team.

6.0 Supporting Attachments / References

None.

7.0 Related Best Practices

None.

8.0 Acknowledgements

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